

Powerpuff Clan

These women lead the way in the corridors of power and redefine the gender equations of Indian politics

Sonia Gandhi

The UPA chairperson does not need any designations to be powerful. Instead, she is the one who appoints presidents and prime ministers.



Pratibha Patil Madame President is now a seasoned first citizen. The UPA Government pulled off a coup in 2007 with the appointment of India's first woman President.



Meira Kumar

The UPA's second coup, India's first woman Speaker of the Lok Sabha. It's an affirmative-action double-whammy, for Kumar is a Dalit too.

Nirupama Rao

India's ambassador to China is India's second woman foreign secretary after Chokila Iyer. The articulate Rao will replace Shiv Shankar Menon who retires end July.

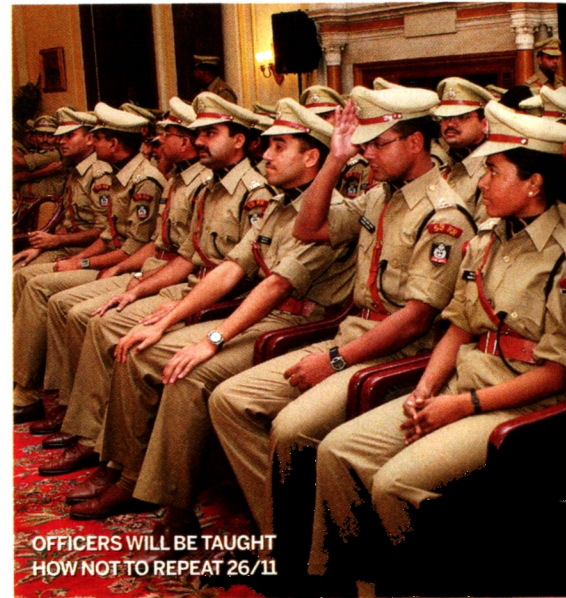
Indira Jai Singh

A social activist and Supreme Court lawyer, Indira Jai Singh is tipped to be the first woman additional solicitor general.

Illustrations by SAURASHI SINGH

DELHI | Brass Tacts

The 26/11 attacks exposed the weaknesses of Mumbai's first line of defence, the city police. In the initial hours of the crisis, it was the first responders, the local police, who could not act decisively. Now the Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel National Police Academy, Hyderabad, will run a week-long course to teach police brass on how to respond to tactical situations like terror strikes and ambushes, rural or urban. Started in March, the course replaces theoretical knowledge with actual field situations and practical shooting and also includes personnel from the paramilitary forces like the BSF, CRPF and ITBP. *by Sandeep Unnithan*



OFFICERS WILL BE TAUGHT HOW NOT TO REPEAT 26/11



MITHUN (THIRD FROM LEFT)

KOLKATA | Higher Goals

After setting the screen on fire with his disco moves, the dance master will now be shaking his leg for a noble cause. Mithun Chakraborty has come to the aid of the Cyclone Aila victims by announcing a charity football match comprising celebrities like Sourav Ganguly and most of Tollywood. "Football is played with brains and not just feet. We are sure to win," Chakraborty says, waving aside the challenge from his opposing captain, Ganguly. That is not all. The Artists Forum, Chakraborty's team, faced a niggling worry over just who they would donate the proceeds to: the secretariat or voluntary organisation since any move can be interpreted as a political choice. He has a sensible way out. "It is only fair that we hand over the proceeds to the Chief Minister's Fund since he is the administrative head of the state," he says. *by Abhijit Dasgupta*

KERALA | Flu Scare

The swine flu scare has reached India's deep south. Six persons tested positive for H1N1 influenza virus in the past two weeks. All of them—two men, two women and two children—are Keralites who had returned home from countries like the Gulf, UK and USA. They have been quarantined in various government hospitals. This has led to anxiety as more than 20 lakh people from Kerala work abroad, mainly in the Gulf.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan